

THE KILLING OF JOHN SPENCER HORNER

Johnson County Civil War Archive

Grant Readiness Package · Version 20.0 · June 2026

Researcher: Daniel Bret Lingar

Location: Clarksville, Johnson County, Arkansas

Contact: lingardaniel1@gmail.com

Archive URL: <https://daniel-lingar.github.io/horner-archive/>

Subject: Guerrilla violence, Civil War Arkansas, Choctaw land dispossession

Period: 1830–1866 (primary focus: August 2, 1864)

This document contains: project overview · interpretive thesis · evidentiary summary · primary sources inventory · open questions register · NARA retrieval queue · grant narrative · institutional affiliation guidance · budget framework · outreach letters

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

On August 2, 1864, a group of approximately twenty Confederate-aligned bushwhackers murdered Unionist farmer John Spencer Horner in his potato patch in Floyd Township, Johnson County, Arkansas. They beat his son William Riley Horner and left him for dead. Eight days later William died in a cave on the mountainside. No one was ever charged. The county sheriff, John Fry Hill — simultaneously a colonel in the Confederate Army — never investigated the crime.

This Grant Readiness Package presents a primary-source documentary archive that reconstructs the Horner killing with exceptional specificity. Built on 19+ federal and state records, including an imaged Choctaw scrip land patent (Certificate 19B), Compiled Military Service Records, pension files, an amnesty petition, GPS-verified sites, and a 1942 family oral history transcript, the archive documents a single 160-acre farm as the convergence point for three major historical forces.

The researcher, Daniel Bret Lingar of Clarksville, Arkansas, is a direct descendant of both the victim family (fifth great-grandson of John Spencer Horner and second great-grandson of eyewitness John Samuel Acord) and the sheriff's family. This double bloodline — created when Horner's grandson married Sheriff Hill's niece — provides a rare, lived perspective on violence, impunity, selective community memory, and eventual public reckoning.

One-Sentence Grant Thesis

The killing of John Spencer Horner on August 2, 1864, offers a fully documented, multi-generational case study — anchored in primary sources and the researcher's direct descent from both the victim family and the sheriff's family — of how Civil War guerrilla violence, the failure of Reconstruction justice, and Choctaw land dispossession converged on a single 160-acre farm in the Arkansas Ozarks.

The project is publicly accessible at <https://daniel-lingar.github.io/horner-archive/>. With targeted support, it will deliver NARA record retrievals, permanent institutional deposit, a peer-reviewed article, and meaningful community engagement in Johnson County.

Requested Funding Range: \$4,500 – \$9,500. The strong existing evidentiary base and public website make this a low-risk, high-reward public humanities project ideally suited for the Arkansas Humanities Council and institutional partnerships.

Project Overview

On August 2, 1864, a group of approximately twenty Confederate-aligned bushwhackers rode to the homestead of John Spencer Horner in Floyd Township, Johnson County, Arkansas. They shot Spencer where he stood in his potato patch, beat his son William Riley Horner with pistols and left him for dead, ransacked the farm for hidden gold, and rode away. Eight days later William died of his wounds in a cave on the mountainside where his wife had carried him. No one was ever charged.

The men who did it were known to the family. The county sheriff — John Fry Hill — was simultaneously a colonel in the Confederate Army, commanding a regiment whose Johnson County companies overlapped with the social network of the attackers. His regiment was documented across the river in Dardanelle the following day. He never investigated.

Spencer's son, Dr. John Turner Horner, led a reprisal squad that allegedly killed seventeen of the twenty men responsible. The official record is entirely silent on this — which is itself a form of evidence about what the community chose not to see.

This archive documents that case. It is built on primary sources: federal land patents, military service records, pension files, a Confederate pension record, an amnesty petition, GPS coordinates, and a 1942 family oral history transcript. The researcher is a direct descendant — fifth great-grandson of Spencer Horner, second great-grandson of John Samuel Acord, the seven-year-old boy who witnessed the murder.

Interpretive Thesis

The killing of Spencer Horner is a documented case study in three intersecting histories that are rarely examined together at the local level:

Civil War Guerrilla Violence in the Arkansas Ozarks

Floyd Township in 1864 was not a battlefield — it was an ungoverned space where the absence of institutional authority enabled targeted political murder. The Horner case puts a specific family, a specific date, and a specific social network on a pattern of violence that the historical record usually describes only in aggregate.

The Failure of Reconstruction Justice at the County Level

The sheriff who did not investigate was also a Confederate colonel. The men who killed Spencer were never charged. The reprisal was extra-judicial and apparently successful — seventeen killings that left no official record. The archive documents how complete impunity operated in one Arkansas county in 1864–1866.

Choctaw Land Dispossession and the Secondary Scrip Market

Spencer Horner's title to the land he died for derived from a Choctaw child's displacement under the Treaty of Dancing Rabbit Creek. Certificate 19B traces a 160-acre child allotment from Mississippi through the speculator market to a Union-aligned farmer in the Arkansas Ozarks — a chain that connects Indian removal in 1830 to Civil War violence in 1864 on the same parcel of ground.

One-sentence grant thesis: *The killing of John Spencer Horner on August 2, 1864 offers a fully documented, multi-generational case study — anchored in primary sources and direct researcher descent — of how Civil War guerrilla violence, the failure of Reconstruction justice, and Choctaw land dispossession converged on a single 160-acre farm in the Arkansas Ozarks.*

Evidentiary Summary

The archive is built on primary sources. The following table summarizes the documentary base and its current status.

Document	Date	Status
Federal Land Patent 19B (Choctaw scrip) — BLM GLO AR2690__,426	April 1, 1857	Imaged
Federal Land Patent 4706 (cash entry) — Fayetteville Land Office	1848	Documented
Northern Neck Proprietary Grant — George Horner / George Washington survey	March 9, 1752	Documented
CMSR — William Riley Horner, Co. K, 2nd Arkansas Infantry (US)	1864	Reviewed
CMSR — Francis Marion Acord, Co. K, 2nd Arkansas Infantry (US)	1864	Reviewed
CMSR — John Fry Hill, 7th Arkansas Cavalry (CSA)	1864	Reviewed
CMSR — Hiram Boen, Co. E, 2nd Arkansas Infantry (US)	1864	Reviewed
CMSR — James Mitchell Wilson, 2nd Arkansas Cavalry (CSA)	1864	Reviewed
John Fry Hill Amnesty Petition to President Andrew Johnson	1866	Reviewed
Widow's Pension — Permelia Turner Horner	Aug 17, 1865	Reviewed
Minor Pension — Dr. John Turner Horner (Acord orphans)	Sept 7, 1865	Reviewed
Rejected Pension — Dr. John Turner Horner, RG 15 App. 1,143,763	1894	NARA — not yet retrieved
Arkansas Ex-Confederate Pension Record — Henry Stewart	1910–1915	Imaged
1942 Horner Family Oral History Transcript (Eva Horner)	1942	Held by researcher
Dewberry GPS Site Survey — Moore Cemetery, homestead, cave	2003	GPS-verified
1850 Federal Census — Johnson County, Mulberry Township	1850	Reviewed
1860 Federal Census — Johnson County, Floyd Township (partial)	1860	Reviewed (partial)

Document	Date	Status
Goodspeed's History of Barry County, MO — Hill biography	1888	Reviewed
Colton's Railroad & Township Map of Arkansas	1860	Documented

Open Questions Register

Questions are classified by what action is required to close them. Priority items are marked.

CLOSE THIS WEEK — Online Retrieval

OQ-21 — Spencer Horner 1860 census property values

Page 981–982, Floyd Township, Johnson County. Ancestry or FamilySearch. Real estate and personal property columns are on the same line as the household head. Closes the question of what Spencer was financially worth in 1864.

OQ-22 — GLO field notes T12N R24W

glorerecords.blm.gov or history.cosl.org → Louisiana Purchase → Transcribed Field Notes → T12N R24W. Field notes describe terrain, timber, and water features section by section — may independently document the bluff and cave corridor.

OQ-12 — William Gordon Acord CMSR

NARA M317, card #44903963. Check Fold3 first. Resolves the unit designation conflict between the tombstone ('CO K 2ND AR INF VOL') and claimed Confederate service.

OQ-13 — Henry Stewart CMSR

NARA M317. Check Fold3 first. Would confirm whether Stewart served in a Johnson County Confederate command (10th Arkansas Militia or 7th Arkansas Cavalry).

OQ-18 — Co-cha-tubbee on Armstrong Roll

Armstrong Roll (1831) digitized on Ancestry and FamilySearch. Search phonetic variants. If found, may show family structure explaining the 160-acre child certificate and identify the parent household claim from which 19B derives.

NARA ORDER — Paid, Weeks Turnaround

OQ-15 ★ PRIORITY — John Turner Horner rejected pension file

RG 15, Application 1,143,763. Filed March 2, 1894; rejected October 5, 1894. Not digitized. Expected to contain sworn service statements and witness affidavits — the most important unretrieved document in the archive. NARA request email drafted; send to inquire@nara.gov.

OQ-16 — Special Order Bo-276-66 — Hiram Boen desertion clearance

NARA RG 94. The War Department cleared Boen's desertion charge in 1866 without stating a reason. The order itself may explain why he was absent during the murders.

OQ-17 + OQ-19 — Fayetteville Land Office register + GLO case file for 19B

NARA RG 49. The Land Office register would document Spencer's filing date, witnesses, and residence. The case file may contain his original application and the Choctaw scrip certificate text. Bundle with OQ-15 order to save turnaround time.

ARCHIVE / LIBRARY — Arkansas History Commission

OQ-23 — Masonic lodge records — Stewart family and Lodges #272 and #118

Yale Cemetery records confirm Thomas Stewart's tombstone was erected by Mulberry Lodge #272; he was a member of Springhill Lodge #118. Grand Lodge records burned 1864 and 1876. Any surviving local records would be at the Arkansas History Commission, Little Rock.

OQ-5 — Dr. John Turner Horner's 10th Arkansas Militia enrollment

His 27-day Confederate muster (Feb–Mar 1862) is confirmed. The 10th Arkansas Militia muster rolls at the Arkansas State Archives may document this original enrollment.

LONG-TERM — Chain Completion

OQ-24 — Parent Choctaw household for Certificate 19B

Certificate 19B (160 acres) indicates Canne Chubbee was an under-ten child in 1831. The head-of-household claimant who registered with agent William Ward has not been identified. Sources: NARA RG 75, Ward's Register (1831), and 1842–1845 commission records.

OQ-20 — Post-1864 deed transfer for the Floyd Township 160 acres

Permelia sold the farm for a horse and wagon after the murders. The actual deed — buyer, date, price — has not been located. Johnson County deed records 1865–1870 not yet examined.

Grant Narrative Draft

The following narrative is suitable for adaptation to NEH Preservation and Access grants, Arkansas Humanities Council project grants, or local history foundation applications. Adjust word count and emphasis to match the specific funder's priorities.

Project Description

On the morning of August 2, 1864, approximately twenty Confederate-aligned bushwhackers rode to the homestead of John Spencer Horner in Floyd Township, Johnson County, Arkansas. They shot him where he stood in his potato patch, beat his son William Riley Horner with pistols, ransacked the farm for hidden gold, and rode away. Eight days later William died of his wounds in a cave on the mountainside. No one was ever charged. The county sheriff, John Fry Hill — simultaneously a colonel in the Confederate Army — never investigated.

This documentary archive reconstructs the event using primary sources with a level of specificity rarely achieved for civilian violence during the Civil War. It is the work of Daniel Bret Lingar, a direct descendant of both the Horner/Acord victims and the Hill family.

Significance

The Horner case illuminates three intersecting histories rarely examined together at the local level:

- Guerrilla violence in the Arkansas Ozarks: Floyd Township in 1864 was an ungoverned space where targeted political murder occurred without institutional restraint.
- The failure of Reconstruction justice at the county level: Sheriff/Colonel John Fry Hill's dual role and the complete absence of investigation exemplify local impunity that persisted into the postwar period.
- Choctaw land dispossession and the secondary scrip market: Spencer Horner's title derived from Certificate 19B, a 160-acre child allotment under the 1830 Treaty of Dancing Rabbit Creek. This connects Indian Removal policy directly to Civil War-era violence on the same parcel of ground.

The Double Bloodline: Victim, Perpetrator Community, and Reconciliation

The Line — From the Murder to the Researcher

This archive exists because of an unbroken chain of survival. Seven people, six generations, 162 years — from a potato patch in Floyd Township to a desk in Clarksville, Arkansas.

Murdered · August 2, 1864 **John Spencer Horner** ~1808–1864 · Floyd Township, Johnson County, Arkansas *Shot in his potato patch. The subject of this archive.*



Spencer's daughter · died March 1, 1864 **Elizabeth Horner Acord** July 10, 1835 – March 1, 1864



Elizabeth's son · age 7 on the day of the murder **John Samuel Acord** December 1, 1856 – March 20, 1928 · Friley, Johnson County, Arkansas



John Samuel's daughter **Rosie Acord Sexton** July 8, 1898 – September 2, 1983 · Johnson County, Arkansas



Rosie's daughter **Argie Faye Sexton Williams** January 6, 1928 – August 29, 2004 · Johnson County, Arkansas



Argie's daughter · Daniel's mother **Patricia Lynn Williams Lingar** December 28, 1956 – December 3, 2021 · Clarksville, Johnson County, Arkansas



Patricia's son · compiler of this archive **Daniel Bret Lingar** September 12, 1982 · Clarksville, Johnson County, Arkansas

2nd great-grandson of John Samuel Acord. 5th great-grandson of John Spencer Horner. This archive exists because a seven-year-old boy survived what happened in that potato patch and his blood eventually produced someone willing to write it down.

The double bloodline. Daniel Lingar descends from both the Horner victims and the Hill family. John Samuel Acord married Amanda Catherine Hill, daughter of Joseph Hill — the Union soldier whose brother John Fry Hill was the Confederate sheriff who never investigated the murder. The boy who watched his grandfather die married into the family of the man who let the killers go free. Both bloodlines run in the same veins today.

This personal connection across the historical divide adds unique interpretive power and positions the project as a vehicle for community dialogue on complicated heritage, selective silence, and truth-telling in Johnson County.

Methods and Deliverables

1. Retrieval of priority NARA records (RG 15 rejected pension file, RG 49 Land Office documents, and related files).
2. Completion of targeted searches (Armstrong Roll, GLO field notes, CMSRs).
3. Substantial expansion of the public digital archive with new findings, high-resolution images, interpretive essays, and interactive mapping.
4. Permanent deposit of the full archive (including the privately held 1942 oral history transcript) with a partner institution.
5. Preparation and submission of a research article to the Arkansas Historical Quarterly.
6. Community engagement deliverables: public presentations, proposal for an Arkansas historical marker, and K-12 educator resources.

Evaluation & Dissemination

Impact will be measured through website analytics, material downloads, citations, event attendance, and institutional deposit confirmation. All new content will be released under open licenses (CC-BY or equivalent) to maximize public access.

Researcher Qualifications

Daniel Bret Lingar is a self-trained genealogical researcher residing in Clarksville, Arkansas — eight miles from the murder site. Over several years he has independently located, imaged, and analyzed dozens of primary federal and state records. His direct descent from both sides of this history provides both intimate knowledge and analytical perspective.

Institutional Affiliation

Most grants from NEH, the Arkansas Humanities Council, and private foundations require an institutional host or fiscal agent. As an independent researcher, Daniel Lingar will need to partner with a qualifying institution before applying to most funders. The following are the strongest candidates.

Butler Center for Arkansas Studies *Central Arkansas Library System, Little Rock* The Butler Center is the state's primary repository for Arkansas history and regularly partners with independent researchers. Their mission directly aligns with the Horner archive's focus on Civil War Arkansas. butlercenter.org

Arkansas Historical Association *University of Arkansas, Fayetteville* The AHA publishes the Arkansas Historical Quarterly and supports local history research. A relationship here would also open a publication pathway for the research paper deliverable.

Johnson County Historical Society & Heritage Center *Clarksville, Arkansas* The local society is the most natural fit given the archive's geographic and community focus. A local institutional home strengthens the case for Arkansas Humanities Council funding specifically, which prioritizes community-based projects.

Arkansas History Commission *Little Rock (State Archives)* The Commission holds the state's archival collections and may be able to facilitate access to records relevant to the open questions, including Masonic lodge records and Arkansas militia muster rolls.

Budget Framework

Modest, scalable request for \$4,500–\$9,500. Strong existing work significantly reduces project risk.

Line Item	Estimated Cost	Notes / Justification
NARA Record Retrieval (RG 15, 49, 94)	\$150 – \$350	Bundled requests; per-page fees
Digital Subscriptions (Fold3, Ancestry, etc.)	\$50 – \$100	Targeted CMSR and Armstrong Roll searches
Travel / Archival Visits or Proxy	\$300 – \$800	Little Rock or NARA researcher
Digitization, Website Enhancements & GIS Mapping	\$600 – \$1,200	Platform improvements, interactive map, accessibility
Oral History Preservation & Deposit	\$200 – \$500	Professional scanning and archival storage
Publication Support	\$100 – \$300	Formatting, possible open-access fees
Community Engagement & Presentations	\$300 – \$600	Local events, marker research, printing
Researcher Stipend (partial)	\$2,000 – \$4,000	Documentation, writing, outreach (150–300 hrs)
Institutional Overhead (10–15%)	\$300 – \$800	If hosted
Contingency & Evaluation	\$200	Unexpected costs and metrics tracking
TOTAL	\$4,500 – \$9,500	Core request ~\$5,500; highly leverageable

Significant in-kind contribution: hundreds of hours already invested, plus existing public website.

Recommended Grant Targets

Arkansas Humanities Councilahc.edu — *annual project grants, typically \$1,000–\$10,000* Best fit. AHC specifically funds community-based Arkansas history projects. Independent researchers can apply with an institutional co-applicant. Deadlines vary; check current cycle. The Horner archive's community connection (Johnson County, Clarksville-based researcher, documented local history) is a strong match.

NEH Preservation and Access — Digitizing Hidden Collectionsneh.gov — *grants typically \$50,000–\$350,000; requires institutional host* Longer-term target. Would require partnership with the Butler Center or Arkansas History Commission. Scope would need to expand beyond a single family archive to a broader collection of Johnson County Civil War materials.

NEH Public Scholar Programneh.gov — *\$60,000 stipend for public-facing research; requires institutional affiliation* Competitive but well-suited to the archive's combination of rigorous primary source work and public accessibility. The interpretive framework (three intersecting histories) is exactly the kind of argument the program funds.

Daughters of the American Revolution — Local Chapter Grantsdar.org — *small grants for genealogical and historical preservation* The Northern Neck Proprietary Grant (1752) and William Horner Sr.'s Revolutionary War service (DAR #462142) establish DAR eligibility. Local chapter grants are small but achievable without institutional affiliation.

Arkansas State Library — LSTA Grantslibrary.arkansas.gov — *Library Services and Technology Act grants* If the archive is formally deposited with a library system, LSTA digitization grants become available. The Butler Center or Johnson County Public Library would be the host.

Immediate Next Steps

This Week

- Send the NARA request email (drafted) to inquire@nara.gov for RG 15, Application 1,143,763.
- Pull 1860 census image pages 981–982, Floyd Township, Johnson County on Ancestry or FamilySearch. Read the real estate and personal property values for W.R. Horne and John T. Homer.
- Go to glorerecords.blm.gov or history.cosl.org and retrieve the field notes for T12N R24W.
- Search Fold3 for Henry Stewart and William Gordon Acord CMSRs before ordering physical copies.
- Search Armstrong Roll on Ancestry or FamilySearch for Co-cha-tubbee (and phonetic variants).

Next 30 Days

- Contact the Johnson County Historical Society in Clarksville and the Butler Center in Little Rock about potential institutional partnership for grant applications.
- Review the Arkansas Humanities Council's current grant cycle and deadlines at ahc.edu.
- Bundle NARA orders for RG 49 (Land Office register + GLO case file) with the RG 15 request to reduce turnaround trips.
- Update archive with 1860 census values and GLO field note findings once retrieved.

Grant Application Window

- Draft full AHC application with institutional co-applicant once a host is identified.
- Write the Arkansas Historical Quarterly article as a standalone deliverable — this strengthens any future grant application and is achievable from the existing research base.
- Consider a DAR chapter grant application as a no-institutional-affiliation option for immediate funding.

Grant Valuation Analysis

Current Realistic Funding Range (Independent): \$4,000 – \$10,000

With Institutional Partner: \$8,000 – \$20,000+

With Partner + Publication + Deposit: \$15,000 – \$40,000+

Factors That Push Value Up

- Exceptional evidentiary depth and specificity.
- Intersectional thesis connecting Civil War violence, Reconstruction failure, and Choctaw dispossession.
- Double bloodline — a compelling, authentic interpretive lens.
- Existing public website as proof-of-concept.
- Researcher's local residency and community ties.

Risk Mitigation

The privately held 1942 oral history transcript will be deposited with a partner institution. All findings will be made publicly available quickly.

Bottom Line

This project is worth substantially more than the current independent ceiling. One institutional partnership (Johnson County Historical Society or Butler Center) combined with the double bloodline narrative dramatically increases fundability. The research is already largely completed — funding will finish, preserve, and amplify it.

Stage	Funding Range	What's Required
Current — independent, no affiliation	\$3,000–\$8,000	AHC small grant, DAR chapter grant
+ Institutional partner	\$8,000–\$15,000	Butler Center, JCHS, or AHA as host
+ Partner + publication submission	\$15,000–\$30,000	AHQ submission + deposit agreement
+ Partner + expanded regional scope	\$50,000+	NEH, co-investigator, full collection

Institutional Outreach Letters

The following letters are ready to send. Send the Johnson County Historical Society letter first — it is the easiest relationship to establish and the most natural fit for an Arkansas Humanities Council application. The Butler Center letter opens the door to larger grants. Send both.

Letter 1 — Johnson County Historical Society

Daniel Bret Lingar

Clarksville, Arkansas

lingardaniel1@gmail.com

June 2026

Johnson County Historical Society & Heritage CenterClarksville, Arkansas

Dear Members of the Johnson County Historical Society,

I am writing to introduce a documentary research project that I believe may be of significant interest to the Society, and to explore the possibility of a formal partnership.

Over the past several years I have built a primary-source archive documenting the murder of John Spencer Horner on August 2, 1864, in Floyd Township, Johnson County. Spencer was shot by Confederate-aligned bushwhackers in his potato patch. His son William was beaten and died eight days later in a cave on the mountainside. The county sheriff — John Fry Hill, simultaneously a colonel in the Confederate Army — never investigated. No one was ever charged.

The archive is built on nineteen primary sources: federal land patents, compiled military service records, pension files, a Confederate pension record, an amnesty petition, GPS-verified site coordinates, and a 1942 family oral history transcript. It is currently published as a public website at daniel-lingar.github.io/horner-archive and is available for review.

I am a direct descendant of the Horner and Acord families — fifth great-grandson of Spencer Horner, second great-grandson of John Samuel Acord, the seven-year-old boy who watched his grandfather get shot. I live in Clarksville, eight miles from the murder site.

I am at the stage where formal institutional partnership would allow me to apply for grant funding — specifically through the Arkansas Humanities Council — to complete the remaining research and deposit the archive permanently. I am not asking the Society to take on administrative burden. What I need is a co-applicant relationship and, ideally, a deposit home for the materials once the project is complete.

I would welcome the opportunity to present the archive to the Society at your convenience and discuss what a partnership might look like. I can be reached at the email address above.

Respectfully,
Daniel Bret Lingar
Clarksville, Arkansas

Letter 2 — Butler Center for Arkansas Studies

Daniel Bret Lingar
Clarksville, Arkansas
lingardaniel1@gmail.com
June 2026

Butler Center for Arkansas Studies
Central Arkansas Library System
100 Rock Street
Little Rock, Arkansas 72201

Dear Butler Center Staff,

I am an independent researcher and lifelong resident of Johnson County, Arkansas, and I am writing to introduce a documentary archive that I believe aligns closely with the Butler Center's mission, and to inquire about the possibility of institutional partnership for grant funding purposes.

The Killing of John Spencer Horner is a primary-source archive documenting the murder of a Unionist farmer in Floyd Township, Johnson County, on August 2, 1864. The archive addresses three intersecting histories rarely examined together at the local level: guerrilla violence in the Arkansas Ozarks, the failure of Reconstruction justice at the county level, and the connection between Choctaw land dispossession under the Treaty of Dancing Rabbit Creek (1830) and Civil War-era land tenure on the same 160-acre parcel.

The evidentiary base includes nineteen primary sources: federal land patents (including an imaged Choctaw scrip patent from 1857), compiled military service records, Union and Confederate pension files, a GPS-verified site survey, and a 1942 family oral history transcript. The archive is currently published at daniel-lingar.github.io/horner-archive and is under active development.

I am seeking an institutional partner for two purposes: first, to qualify for Arkansas Humanities Council and NEH grant funding for the completion of outstanding NARA record retrievals and a formal research publication; and second, to ensure permanent preservation of the archive materials, including the privately held 1942 oral history transcript, which currently exists in a single copy.

I recognize that the Butler Center regularly partners with independent researchers and community historians. I am not asking for staff resources or ongoing administrative support — I am asking whether the Center would be willing to serve as institutional host on a grant application and as a deposit home for the completed archive. I am happy to provide the full research dossier, the existing grant package, and references from the Johnson County community.

I would welcome a conversation at your earliest convenience.

With appreciation,

Respectfully,

Daniel Bret Lingar

Clarksville, Arkansas

Letter 3 — Arkansas Humanities Council (Letter of Inquiry)

Daniel Bret Lingar

Clarksville, Arkansas

lingardaniel1@gmail.com

June 2026

Arkansas Humanities Council 407 President Clinton Avenue, Suite 201 Little Rock, Arkansas
72201

Dear Arkansas Humanities Council Program Staff,

I am writing to inquire whether a project I have been developing over the past several years would be a suitable candidate for an Arkansas Humanities Council project grant, and to request guidance on the appropriate grant mechanism and current deadlines.

The project is a documentary archive documenting the murder of John Spencer Horner on August 2, 1864, in Floyd Township, Johnson County, Arkansas — eight miles from where I live today in Clarksville. Spencer was shot by Confederate-aligned bushwhackers. His son died eight days later. The county sheriff, who was simultaneously a Confederate colonel, never investigated. I am a direct descendant of the family.

The archive is built on nineteen primary sources and addresses questions of genuine public humanities significance: How did ordinary Arkansans experience guerrilla violence during the Civil War? How did the failure of Reconstruction justice play out at the county level? How does Choctaw land dispossession connect to the land tenure disputes that drove Civil War-era violence in northwest Arkansas? The archive is published and accessible at daniel-lingar.github.io/horner-archive.

The proposed grant activities would fund: retrieval of key NARA records not yet obtained (specifically a rejected pension file and land office registers that are central to the research); preparation of a formal research article for submission to the Arkansas Historical Quarterly; and permanent deposit of the archive with an Arkansas institution. The total budget for these activities is estimated at \$4,500–\$9,500 depending on scope and whether researcher compensation is included.

I am currently in conversation with potential institutional partners in Johnson County and Little Rock. I would welcome any guidance the Council can offer on the appropriate grant mechanism, eligibility requirements for independent researchers, and the current application cycle.

Thank you for your time and consideration.

Respectfully,

Daniel Bret Lingar

Clarksville, Arkansas